

Marco Carenza

Karina Popp

Game Studies

5/5/2026

Fighting games and the Fighting Game Community (FGC): How their history led them to diverge from other competitive genres

I have been playing fighting games since I was a kid, spamming special moves whenever I could because I thought they were obviously better than normal moves, as they are called “special” for a reason. I never really wanted to get better at these games, I enjoyed sitting around with my friends and family beating each other up, until one of us remained victorious. However, when high school came around, I started playing games on my Xbox One and saw this one fighting game that had an old Japanese man doing an electric uppercut sending a grizzly bear flying in the air. This was my introduction to *Tekken 7*, a game that would forever change the games I play and enjoy. Through *Tekken 7* I learned of the world of fighting games and became part of the Fighting Game community (FGC), falling in love with the genre as a whole. As anyone would, I tried asking my friends to play some of these games with me, but they constantly refused. What confused me the most is that I thought that my friends would love playing fighting games, as they constantly played other competitive games such as *League of Legends*, *CSGO (Counter Strike Global Offensive)*, and *Overwatch*. With this paper I wanted to investigate what makes fighting games and its community so different from other competitive games and their communities. I will be diving into fighting games’ history and how the community evolved to what they are today. Overall, my findings were that fighting games

diverge from other genres due to their arcade origins, with the lack of serviceable online services leading the Fighting Game Community (FGC) to rely and develop their own offline spaces known as locals. Additionally, fighting games tend to be individual play compared to team-play like other genres, leading to the outcome of each match being directly tied to your performance. Finally, they are a hard genre to get into, so those who get into the genre tend to stick with the genre.

Before discussing the distinctions that separate fighting games and other competitive video game genres, we must first go what fighting games are and their history. Todd Harper and his influential book (*The Culture of Digital Fighting Games- Performance and Practice*) outline five key points that define what a fighting game is. According to Todd Harper, a fighting game is: a game of close-quarters combat, typically physical combat between on-screen characters, which may involve some projectiles like the iconic “Hadouken” (13). The characters in fighting games have standard and special attacks, or “moves”, typically the more complex input the better the payoff (13). These games’ match parameters are quantified on-screen in some way, such as life bars, game timers and super meters (13). Fighting games are competitive, as the goal of a match is to determine a winner, typically requiring a player to reduce the other’s health to zero (14). Finally, these games allow for multiplayer competition, as this feature distinguishes fighting games from “beat ‘em ups” such as *Final Fight* or *Double Dragon* (14).

The Fighting Game Community (FGC) refers to the collective community of all the players and fans of the genre. It is not a specific community that follows a specific game or set of conventions, rather the FGC has various communities within it typically subdivided by game or fighting game subgenre that they most like to play.

As mentioned by Todd Harper, as well as being mentioned in *Tusslers, Beatdowns, and Brothers: A Sociohistorical Overview of Video Game Arcades and the Street Fighter Community* by Michael Ryan Skolnik and Steven Conway, fighting games are born out of the game arcades in the 90s, Street Fighter 2 being the game that popularized the genre. The seventh generation of consoles (Xbox 360, Playstation 3, etc) was the nail in the coffin that ended the arcade era of fighting games. Home consoles became the more economic option for players, as players would have a bigger initial purchase cost, however in the long run it would end up being cheaper instead of the constant spending on an arcade machine. In return the players had a variably degraded gameplay experience due to factors like network latency (lag), but the players would play from the comfort of their homes, on a couch, or whenever they wanted to play on instead of arcade cabinets. When players are competing side by side sharing an arcade cabinet the machine would register both players' input at the same time, creating a smooth gameplay experience. However, with online play it requires two devices to send data back and forth to each other, with the devices trying to ensure that both players see the same thing at any given time, meaning a game (through its netcode) needs to figure out a way to achieve this.

According to Ricky Pusch's article *Explaining How Fighting Games Use Delay-Based and Rollback Netcode*, the way delay based netcode worked is that it artificially delays a player's input so that both players can "receive" the inputs at the same time. So if a player's inputs are arriving late when sent over the network, delay-based strategies delay the local player's inputs by the same amount of time. In fighting games time is measured in a unit called a frame, typically the genre operates at 60 frames per second, so one frame is around 16 milliseconds (ms) of real time. Most of the time a delay isn't noticeable by players as typically the delay is only 3-5 frames (48-80 ms), however if the connection is ever affected this small delay can fluctuate and jump up

drastically to 20 frames (320 ms) or more. This lack of consistency is the issue, as it leads to slowed down and unresponsive gameplay. Fighting games as a genre require specifically timed inputs for special moves and combos, making any sort of input delay make the play experience suboptimal. The variance of consistent latency disrupts a player's muscle memory and their reactions which are core to every fighting game. Because of these factors, for a long time online play wasn't seen as "real fighting game play", as anyone who was taking the games seriously would play them offline.

So, with online play being subpar and arcades being closed, where would people go to play "real fighting game" now that arcades are gone? The community stepped up and created local spaces for people to play in. Some of these places would evolve, scale and eventually grow into large events that attracted people from all over the world. Such is the case for Evolution Championship Series (EVO), which according to game journalist Jack Ridsdale is now known as the biggest fighting game tournament in the world. The Fighting Game Community (FGC) had superseded the arcade with their new spaces, however, as Seth Killian (one of the EVO organizers) has said "EVO isn't about bringing back arcades, but preserving this fire, this passion, this connection." (Harper, 21) in reference to the FGC's love for fighting games. These local spaces are colloquially known as "locals", and generally they are split into two main types, Majors and Locals. Majors which are larger, more competitive events in big large venues, they are the events where people travel from all over to prove they are the best. Typically the games are recorded, or live streamed for those who can't attend, as high level matches are very entertaining to the community. These big events typically have sponsors covering for equipment and costs, with some examples being EVO, CEO, Frosty Foustings, etc. Locals on the other hand are the smaller more casual events. It's a space where people convene to meet people with the

same interests and maybe make friends. These events rely on community help to keep it running, as it's the members who supply the different controllers, consoles, monitors, etc to play on. They are typically hosted in bars, schools, stores, anywhere that can house a good number of people and isn't too expensive to reserve.

However, in the decades since the death of the arcade, a major world event had occurred that caused all of these offline spaces to close and created an online renaissance in fighting games. The 2019 COVID pandemic had destroyed and gotten rid of all the available offline spaces to participate in, as the lockdowns restrictions forced public places to shut down and mandated everyone to stay at home. This forced many players to turn to online play to scratch their fighting game itch, which as previously mentioned was relatively lackluster due to the degraded gameplay experience created by the lag. Fortunately, for the FGC, Tony Cannon (one of the founders of EVO) was hard at work creating good netcode for fighting games called GGPO colloquially referred to as rollback netcode. Rollback was able to drastically improve their online functionality, leading to “smooth, reliable, consistent online play that can connect communities worldwide” (Pusch). Due to it being open-source in 2019, GGPO started being implemented in various fighting games, with *Guilty Gear Strive* being the first major release that solidified the importance of having rollback online play. Now with good online play the genre is exploding in popularity, as many franchises newest game installments have sold vast amounts of copies such as *Street Fighter 6* selling over 6 Million copies, *Mortal Kombat 1* selling over 8 Million copies (Justin Gordon). Due to all of these new games employing rollback netcode, people are now comfortable with just playing online, leading to a new generation of fighting game players who have almost exclusively played online. I am part of this generation who mostly just played their fighting games online without going to many, or any at all, locals and

other tournaments. This claim can be seen through the comparisons of sales compared to EVO (or other major tournaments) registrants, with there being a lot more players than tournament goers, with games like Street Fighter selling over 6 Million copies, while EVO Japan entries are only 7 thousand (Glaze).

However, even with the improvement of online play, people still felt that playing fighting games online wasn't the same as playing them offline. As various forums, social media, and other online hubs, people still wanted to play these games against a person offline. An example would be user ScOULaris asking on the resetera forums "Are you able to enjoy fighting games offline?", with many of the responses signaling their preference for playing offline compared to playing online (ScOULaris). Overall, playing in the comfort of your own home is convenient, but doesn't give the same experience as going to a fighting game local, as being in a shared space with people playing the same game competitively. The energy is different, you can feel the passion and commitment people have for these games, and there's nothing like it really. As Todd Harper states "Those respondents who had attended tournaments or events like EVO in the past—particularly those who have attended an actual EVO tournament—spoke to their great affection for such situations, where players are gathered together in a physical space to play matches against one another while other enthusiasts are there to watch and take part". This want for offline spaces can be shown through the previously mentioned record breaking number of entrants that have registered to EVO Japan this year (Glaze), with over 7,000 players lined up to compete.

The FGC still yearns for an offline space, and this is a major point in where fighting games and its community diverge from other competitive genres. Fighting games are best in local spaces, and they embrace that. Members of all skill levels participate with locals, as they

are run by passionate people who want to share their love of fighting games with everyone else. Other genres such as FPSs, RTSs, MOBAs, do have offline events, however these are almost exclusively held for the top bracket of players. You would rarely see an offline event where players of all skill levels gather together and play. This is because for these other genres, online play was the most accessible and normalized form of play. Fighting games having subpar online play, forced them to foster offline communities for all that were really passionate about the genre.

Before outlining other differences between fighting games and competitive genres, first I want to highlight some similarities that they have. According to “Appeal of Playing Online First Person Shooter Games by” Jeroen Jansz , Martin Tanis and “EXPLAINING THE ENJOYMENT OF PLAYING VIDEO GAMES: THE ROLE OF COMPETITION” by Peter Vorderer, other competitive genres, are inherently competitive, as even the more casual fans or game modes require at a bare minimum they want to beat their opponents through fighting.

As mentioned in both “Playing with the Rules: Social and Cultural Aspects of Game Rules in a Console Game Club” by Mikael Jakobsson and the previously mentioned paper by Jansz and Tanis, competitive games tend to have a divide between high level and lower level players. Differing ways of play are created depending on player skill level. With the higher level players also gaining a superiority complex due to their skill at the game.

A final similarity that all online games have, not even just competitive ones is toxicity. Online anonymity makes people be the nastiest they can be. People always put down themselves or teammates, in order to excuse poor performance.

Other differences that fighting games have compared to other competitive genres is that almost exclusively a 1v1 genre (with exception being tag games where you can play a 2v2 or

3v3). Its reliance on offline events, as mentioned previously, creates a stronger sense of community. And as Patrick Miller states “Why fighting games are hard” fighting games are more difficult to get into than other genres. He argues that “The moves are too hard to do”, as most other genres don’t require an entry level player to do motion inputs to play, “There’s too much stuff to memorize” each character can have a lot (in the case of Tekken hundreds) of different moves, making it intimidating play, as well as “They’re too fast” to an inexperienced player they just don’t know what is happening and lose. The genre is hard due to it being a single player competitive experience where you cannot be passive and win, you need to lose a lot, and figure out yourselves actively how to win. There is no team to rely on, or blame for your loss, you need to figure out your character first, and deal with whatever the opponent throws at you.

In conclusion, fighting games and the FGC diverge from other competitive genres because of their history. Its reliance on arcade spaces in combination with the online play being subpar created a community that craved offline spaces and loved community driven local events. Fighting games are almost exclusively a singleplayer competitive game, and have other reasons as to why the genre is difficult to get into. However, fighting games being so difficult to get into means that those who love the genre tend to stick with it, creating a stronger both with the genre and other community members.

Bibliography

Cruz, Victor de la. “Why It’s Hard to Get Good at Fighting Games.” 3rd World Geeks, 30 Jan. 2018, 3rdworldgeeks.com/2018/01/30/why-fighting-games-are-hard-to-get-good-at/. Accessed 24 Apr. 2026.

Glaze, Virginia. “Evo Japan Sets World Record with Biggest Street Fighter Tournament

Ever.” *Dexerto*, 4 May 2026,

www.dexerto.com/street-fighter/evo-japan-sets-record-with-biggest-street-fighter-tournament-ever-3357987/. Accessed 05 May 2026.

Gordon, Justin. “Ed Boon Reveals That Mortal Kombat 1 Has Continued to Sell Well after the Definitive Edition Release.” *EventHubs*, 16 Aug. 2025,

www.eventhubs.com/news/2025/aug/16/boon-sales-mk1-continued-strong/. Accessed 05 May 2026.

Gordon, Justin. “Street Fighter 6 Revealed to Have Sold over 6.36 Million Units as of December 31, 2025.” *EventHubs*, 27 Jan. 2026,

www.eventhubs.com/news/2026/jan/27/sf6-636-million-sales-lifetime/. Accessed 05 May 2026.

funkyfelis. “R/Fighters on Reddit: Fighting Games Are Uniquely Hard to Get into Because They Don’t Allow Beginners to Be Passive.” Reddit, Feb. 2026, www.reddit.com/r/Fighters/comments/1rfu9b7/fighting_games_are_uniquely_hard_to_get_into/. Accessed 25 Apr. 2026.

Harper, Todd. *The Culture of Digital Fighting Games: Performance and Practice*. 2013.

Jakobsson, Mikael. *Playing with the Rules: Social and Cultural Aspects of Game Rules in a Console Game Club*, May 2011,

www.researchgate.net/publication/228361473_Playing_with_the_Rules_Social_and_Cultural_Aspects_of_Game_Rules_in_a_Console_Game_Club. Accessed 25 Apr. 2026.

Pusch, Ricky. “Explaining How Fighting Games Use Delay-Based and Rollback Netcode.” *Ars Technica*, 18 Oct. 2019,

arstechnica.com/gaming/2019/10/explaining-how-fighting-games-use-delay-based-and-rollback-netcode/. Accessed 05 May 2026.

Online vs Offline Fighting Games: The Truth? - Fighting Game Discussion - Shoryuken Forums Archive, archive.supercombo.gg/t/online-vs-offline-fighting-games-the-truth/83796. Accessed 25 Apr. 2026.

Ridsdale, Jack. “Why Evo Is Still the Biggest Event in Fighting Games.” *Red Bull*, Red Bull, 28 Apr. 2026, www.redbull.com/us-en/why-evo-biggest-fighting-game-event. Accessed 05 May 2026.

ScOULaris. “Are You Able to Enjoy Fighting Games Offline?” ResetEra, 1 July 2024, www.resetera.com/threads/are-you-able-to-enjoy-fighting-games-offline.916074/. Accessed 24 Apr. 2026.

Skolnik, Michael Ryan, and Steven Conway. “Tusslers, Beatdowns, and Brothers: A Sociohistorical Overview of Video Game Arcades and the Street Fighter Community - Michael Ryan Skolnik, Steven Conway, 2019.” Sage Journals, 28 Aug. 2017, journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/1555412017727687. Accessed 25 Apr. 2026.